

Week 21: Text

BIG IDEA

No original 'autographs' of any ancient text survive, only manuscript copies. With over 6,000 New Testament manuscripts agreeing more than 95 percent — variants affecting no theology — the New Testament is better attested than the sources behind school history textbooks. What Paul wrote and Jesus said is what we actually have.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- An article claimed the Epistle of Barnabas proves Jesus never resurrected; this unit tackles how we know the Bible is true, accurate, and authoritative.
- Answering 'the Bible is true because the Bible says so' is a circle; we need something exterior to establish whether it is actually true.
- No autographs (originals) survive from antiquity, only manuscripts — copies, sometimes copies of copies — so the question is whether we have enough accurate ones.
- Pliny's Natural History, a source behind Roman history in textbooks, survives in roughly 100 copies; the New Testament in over 6,000, over 20,000 counting related texts.
- Across all the copies the text agrees in excess of 95 percent, and the differences — words like 'the' and 'a' — affect no theology.
- Critic Bart Ehrman calls these 'error-ridden copies,' but the evidence contradicts him; help students weigh such mainstream media voices critically — Jonathan Morrow's Questioning the Bible helps.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What's the difference between an autograph and a manuscript, and why does that matter for the New Testament?
2. How does the New Testament's manuscript evidence compare with the ancient sources your textbooks treat as fact?
3. When someone like Bart Ehrman says the Bible is full of errors, how would you respond?
4. If the Bible really is reliable, what will that mean for your life today, tomorrow, and down the road?

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